

What DBI's Permit Record Contains, and whether the projects that reach the Commission are different

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Abstract

The permit-linkage memo used DBI's Building Permits table as a lookup: find the permit the hearing was about and read off its outcome. This memo reads the table itself. It inventories every column from the rows rather than the documentation, describes the permit clock, defines a development-relevant universe, and asks the question the real-options frame needs answered before any linked outcome is interpreted: *do the projects that appear in the minutes look different from observably similar projects that do not?*

The table is mostly not about development. It holds 1,295,168 rows for 1,149,352 permits filed from 1901 to 2026; 76.6% of the permits are over-the-counter alterations. Under stated rules 57,883 permits — 5.0% — are development-relevant: new construction, demolition, site permits, and alterations that change the unit count or sit in the top 5% of their year's cost. 4,517 of them (7.8%) are Commission-linked, through a permit number printed in the minutes or the Planning records' own permit field.

Linked projects are bigger and slower, and the difference in time survives the comparison within cells. Their median estimated cost is \$325,000 against \$145,000; the standardised difference in log cost is 0.43 raw and 0.19 within cells of permit type, filing period and neighbourhood. From filing to issuance they take a median 500 days against 191; that difference is 0.71 raw and still 0.43 within cells — the largest gap in the comparison after the filing year itself. Linked permits are less often abandoned (20.9% expired or withdrawn against 31.7%), and the difference narrows to -0.16 within cells.

The developer's clock on the DR track starts well before the Planning record does. From the filing of the permit a discretionary review is about to the first DR hearing is a median 294 days; from the opening of the Planning record the data-acquisition memo used, 101. On the cases with both, the permit clock is a median 150 days longer.

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1 What is in the table

The source is DataSF’s *Building Permits* (i98e-djp9), fetched in full — every column the resource endpoint returns — on 2026-09-11. The permit-linkage memo’s cache held twenty-two chosen columns, which suited matching permit numbers and does not suit a question about what the record contains. The full fetch has 57 columns: 4 Socrata system fields and 53 data columns. The download paged on the system row identifier rather than on an offset, so a daily update landing mid-download cannot shift a page; 0 identifiers came back twice.

Table 1 gives every column’s kind, inferred from the values, its populated share overall and by the decade the permit was filed, and its number of distinct values. Table 2 gives the three most frequent values of each and, for 17 columns, the measurement showing that the rows do not deliver what the column’s name promises. The ones that matter for this project:

- **record_id** is DBI’s own identifier. None of its values has the shape of a Planning case or record number; the name invites a join that does not exist.
- **first_construction_document_date** — the permit memo’s “construction started” — is effectively absent before the late 1990s, and Table 5 shows the consequence: the share of permits with a construction start reads as zero for the 1980s because the field is empty, not because nothing was built.
- **estimated_cost** carries placeholder values: its note gives the share at \$1 or less.
- The one-valued flags — **site_permit**, **structural_notification**, **fire_only_permit**, **reroof**, **primary_address_flag** — record only Y. A blank means “no” or “not recorded”, and the table cannot say which.

Table 1: Every column of the Building Permits table as it is actually filled: the share of rows with a value, overall and by the decade the permit was filed, and the number of distinct values. ‘Kind’ is inferred from the values, not the documentation.

Field	Kind	All	<1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	Distinct
:id	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,295,168
:created_at	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	316
:updated_at	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	318
:version	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,295,168
permit_number	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,149,358
permit_type	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	9
permit_type_definition	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	8
permit_creation_date	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	103,230
block	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	5,242
lot	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,578
street_number	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	5,940
street_number_suffix	text	1.0	1	1	1	1	1	2	25
street_name	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,965
street_suffix	text	98.8	99	100	99	98	99	99	24
unit	number	11.5	13	10	9	10	14	13	1,186
unit_suffix	text	0.8	0	0	0	1	1	1	353

Field	Kind	All	<1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	Distinct
description	text	98.6	86	88	100	100	100	100	806,523
status	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	23
status_date	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	543,143
filed_date	date	99.9	100	100	100	100	100	100	791,153
issued_date	date	95.0	86	91	97	97	95	92	766,198
completed_date	date	57.8	16	70	54	52	58	65	252,956
first_construction_	date	1.2	0	0	0	2	2	0	12,932
document_date									
approved_date	date	95.2	88	94	98	97	95	87	760,114
structural_	flag	4.0	4	7	4	4	3	3	1
notification									
number_of_existing_	code	84.1	17	87	98	76	78	90	136
stories									
number_of_proposed_	code	79.2	24	82	78	76	77	90	146
stories									
voluntary_soft_story_	flag	0.0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1
retrofit									
fire_only_permit	flag	4.2	0	0	0	0	9	13	1
estimated_cost	number	88.9	79	98	99	83	80	97	38,813
revised_cost	number	69.4	1	4	9	98	98	98	40,837
existing_use	text	86.9	17	87	98	84	79	95	99
existing_units	number	80.5	16	85	96	76	72	80	629
proposed_use	text	86.2	21	86	97	83	78	94	99
proposed_units	number	81.6	26	94	97	75	72	80	636
plansets	number	90.1	100	100	100	85	80	97	15
tidf_compliance	text	0.1	3	0	0	0	0	0	4
existing_occupancy	text	86.5	30	85	96	84	78	96	4,123
proposed_occupancy	text	87.2	42	94	97	83	78	95	4,818
existing_	code	79.1	2	80	78	76	77	90	6
construction_type									
existing_	text	79.1	2	80	78	76	77	90	5
construction_type_									
description									
proposed_	code	78.9	3	82	77	76	77	90	11
construction_type									
proposed_	text	78.9	3	82	77	76	77	90	5
construction_type_									
description									
site_permit	flag	2.4	6	0	3	3	3	1	1
last_permit_activity_	date	92.3	4	63	83	100	100	100	770,130
date									
application_	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	3
submission_method									
adu	flag	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	2
primary_address_flag	flag	88.7	83	86	86	88	91	92	1
supervisor_district	code	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	11
neighborhoods_	text	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	41
analysis_boundaries									
zipcode	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	30
location	geometry	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	165,124
point_source	text	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	2
reroof	flag	9.0	0	0	15	9	7	13	1

Field	Kind	All	<1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	Distinct
record_id	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,295,168
data_as_of	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	310
data_loaded_at	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	310

Table 2: The three most frequent values of every column, and where the rows do not deliver what the column’s name promises, the measurement that shows it.

Field	Most frequent values	What the rows deliver
:id	row-wauk.mkk3-gckg; row-xq6s.i3xf-zu6u; row-se43.buxg_jd5r	
:created_at	2025-08-07T19:01:07.429Z; 2025-09-19T18:00:27.535Z; 2025-12-17T12:38:37.287Z	
:updated_at	2025-08-08T10:43:49.464Z; 2026-01-11T12:54:43.122Z; 2026-01-25T12:42:22.649Z	
:version	rv-9k3i jnx8 8m39; rv-zjxp_gwts-tey6; rv-vyud.w9y9-kc6c	
permit_number	201602179765; 201602179758; 201602179775	
permit_type	8; 3; 4	
permit_type_definition	otc alterations permit; additions alterations or rep; sign - erect	
permit_creation_date	2017-09-15T00:00:00.000; 1991-08-30T00:00:00.000; 2015-11-03T00:00:00.000	the same day as filed_date on 99.7% of rows
block	3708; 3709; 0289	
lot	001; 007; 006	
street_number	1; 101; 50	
street_number_suffix	A; V; B	filled on 0.99% of rows
street_name	Market; California; Mission	
street_suffix	St; Av; Bl	
unit	0; 1; 2	
unit_suffix	A; B; C	filled on 0.83% of rows
description	reroofing; street space; street space permit	
status	complete; issued; expired	
status_date	1983-03-04T00:00:00.000; 2026-01-09T08:39:29.000; 1986-03-04T00:00:00.000	
filed_date	1991-08-30T00:00:00.000; 1999-06-30T00:00:00.000; 1990-09-27T00:00:00.000	
issued_date	1999-01-15T00:00:00.000; 1987-07-06T00:00:00.000; 1989-11-08T00:00:00.000	

Field	Most frequent values	What the rows deliver
completed_date	1983-03-04T00:00:00.000; 1986-03-04T00:00:00.000; 1992-05-13T00:00:00.000	filled on 100.0% of permits with status 'complete'
first_construction_document_date	2019-12-31T00:00:00.000; 2002-11-05T12:49:18.000; 2009-05-13T16:29:31.000	on issued new-construction permits: filled on 0.05% of those filed in the 1980s, 11.9% in the 1990s, 69.6% in the 2000s
approved_date	1994-08-30T00:00:00.000; 1989-11-30T00:00:00.000; 1999-01-14T00:00:00.000	
structural_notification	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 4.0% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
number_of_existing_stories	2; 3; 1	
number_of_proposed_stories	2; 3; 1	
voluntary_soft_story_retrofit	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 0.01% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
fire_only_permit	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 4.2% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
estimated_cost	1.0; 5000.0; 10000.0	\$1 or less on 10.2% of filled rows; the most frequent value is \$1
revised_cost	1.0; 0.0; 5000.0	filled on 3.6% of permits filed in the 1980s, 98.3% in the 2010s
existing_use	1 family dwelling; apartments; office	
existing_units	1.0; 0.0; 2.0	filled on 94.4% of additions and alterations (blank on new construction, where nothing exists)
proposed_use	1 family dwelling; apartments; 2 family dwelling	
proposed_units	1.0; 0.0; 2.0	filled on 97.6% of new-construction permits
plansets	2; 0; 3	
tidf_compliance	Y; R; P	filled on 0.07% of rows
existing_occupancy	R-3; R-1; R-2	
proposed_occupancy	R-3; R-1; R-2	
existing_construction_type	5; 1; 3	
existing_construction_type_description	wood frame (5); constr type 1; constr type 3	
proposed_construction_type	5; 1; 3	
proposed_construction_type_description	wood frame (5); constr type 1; constr type 3	

Field	Most frequent values	What the rows deliver
site_permit	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 2.4% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
last_permit_activity_date	1960-01-01T00:00:00.000; 1994-08-30T00:00:00.000; 1999-01-14T00:00:00.000	
application_submission_method	in-house; website; epr website	
adu	N; Y	
primary_address_flag	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 88.7% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
supervisor_district	3; 8; 2	
neighborhoods_analysis_boundaries	Financial District/South Bea; Mission; Sunset/Parkside	
zipcode	94110; 94114; 94117	
location	POINT (-122.394985937 37.793; POINT (-122.403518141 37.792; POINT (-122.398125294 37.791	
point_source	eas_address_point; parcel_centroid	
rerroof	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 9.0% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
record_id	1410598100118; 141060174315; 1410604404163	
data_as_of	2025-08-07T23:55:01.000; 2026-01-11T01:05:01.000; 2026-01-25T01:05:00.000	not a Planning record: 0.0% of values have a case-number shape; DBI's own identifier
data_loaded_at	2025-08-08T03:30:43.448; 2026-01-11T04:54:22.840; 2026-01-25T04:42:11.762	

Table 3: Permits by type and filing decade, one row per permit number (the earliest-filed row of each).

Permit type	before 1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	no filed date	All
(type 9, undefined)	0	0	0	0	0	555	89	644
additions, alterations or repairs	217	72,026	74,191	47,919	21,892	8,813	412	225,470
demolition	1	1,668	1,450	1,672	1,002	434	26	6,253
grade or excavate	0	103	167	208	135	55	4	672
new construction	24	576	264	332	584	176	12	1,968
new construction, wood frame	14	3,767	3,154	2,214	1,235	455	35	10,874
over-the-counter alterations	3	37,621	144,500	251,014	306,443	139,967	426	879,974
sign — erect	2	4,363	3,470	3,715	5,333	2,894	6	19,783
wall or painted sign	0	655	1,001	744	913	398	3	3,714
All	261	120,779	228,197	307,818	337,537	153,747	1,013	1,149,352

Table 4: Status, one row per permit. The exits — expired, withdrawn, cancelled, disapproved, revoked, suspended — are the trace of a project that did not proceed.

Status	Permits	Share
complete	658,548	57.3%
issued	224,334	19.5%
expired †	203,029	17.7%
cancelled †	38,199	3.3%
filed	10,451	0.9%
withdrawn †	9,778	0.9%
reinstated	1,330	0.1%
approved	952	0.1%
filing	920	0.1%
suspend †	575	0.1%
disapproved †	491	0.0%
triage	401	0.0%
revoked †	221	0.0%
plancheck	43	0.0%
appeal	23	0.0%
issuing	23	0.0%
(blank)	12	0.0%
denied	8	0.0%
inspection	4	0.0%
incomplete	3	0.0%
unknown	3	0.0%
upheld	2	0.0%
granted	1	0.0%
overruled	1	0.0%

Table 5: The permit clock by type and filing decade: the share reaching each stage, and the median days between stages among permits that reached both. Negative intervals are excluded from the medians and counted in the text. Recent decades are right-censored.

Type	Filed	Permits	Issued	Filed → issued		Started	Issued → start	Completed	Issued → done	Exited
				median	p90					
new construction (types 1, 2)	1980s	4,343	85.4%	177	527	0.0%	560	68.7%	335	29.9%
	1990s	3,418	87.5%	278	1,245	10.1%	13	68.3%	400	29.0%
	2000s	2,546	80.0%	410	1,475	55.0%	13	61.9%	573	30.2%
	2010s	1,819	74.5%	437	1,533	51.1%	195	55.3%	941	15.3%
	2020s	631	42.3%	453	1,090	17.0%	307	13.3%	792	9.4%
additions and alterations (3)	before 1980	217	87.6%	74	706	0.0%	—	12.4%	2,598	78.8%
	1980s	72,026	87.7%	36	155	0.0%	—	65.3%	144	33.8%
	1990s	74,191	91.6%	37	182	0.6%	0	56.2%	135	43.0%
	2000s	47,919	88.6%	51	315	10.2%	2	56.1%	194	35.8%
	2010s	21,892	79.8%	223	734	20.1%	120	60.2%	381	21.8%
	2020s	8,813	69.1%	225	717	6.3%	224	39.2%	328	11.5%
demolition (6)	1980s	1,668	86.3%	39	265	0.0%	—	73.4%	102	24.8%
	1990s	1,450	87.0%	177	573	0.0%	—	66.3%	152	23.4%
	2000s	1,672	76.9%	279	1,154	0.0%	—	55.3%	182	28.1%
	2010s	1,002	82.0%	234	1,129	0.0%	—	62.9%	351	13.1%
	2020s	434	62.4%	148	841	0.0%	—	38.7%	153	6.0%
over-the-counter (8)	1980s	37,621	97.9%	0	0	0.0%	—	77.7%	85	22.4%
	1990s	144,500	99.8%	0	0	0.0%	—	53.2%	69	47.2%
	2000s	251,014	99.1%	0	0	0.0%	0	51.0%	85	23.4%
	2010s	306,443	96.7%	0	22	0.0%	0	57.9%	105	5.9%
	2020s	139,967	93.9%	0	60	0.0%	0	68.2%	101	5.3%

Table 6: The development-relevant universe, rule by rule, over the 269,378 permits that are not over-the-counter alterations. ‘Alone’ is what the rule keeps by itself; ‘added’ is what it adds to the rules above it. The cost rule is the top 5% of additions-and-alterations estimated cost within the filing year; the sensitivity rows swap it for the alternatives.

Rule	Alone	Added
new construction	12,842	12,842
demolition	6,253	6,253
site permit	26,146	19,477
alteration changing units	12,219	9,355
alteration over the cost threshold	11,697	9,956
Universe		57,883
of which Commission-linked (T1 or T2)		4,517
of which T3 only		1,773
Over-the-counter permits excluded	879,974	
<i>Sensitivity: the cost rule replaced by</i>		
top 10%	67,041	6.8% linked
top 2%	51,871	8.6% linked
nominal \$1M	50,315	9.0% linked

Table 7: The linkage tiers. Items is item-table rows that reach at least one permit by the tier; permits is distinct DBI permits reached, all and within the development-relevant universe. T3’s precision was measured on discretionary reviews, where the printed number is ground truth, and is unmeasured elsewhere.

Tier	Items	Permits	In the universe
T1: permit number printed in the minutes	3,515	2,239	1,890
T2: Planning records’ building_permits	7,864	5,518	4,042
T3: parcel + type + window	6,664	8,427	3,615
T1 and T2 both		1,627	1,415
Commission-linked (T1 or T2)		6,130	4,517

Table 8: Commission-linked permits against development-relevant permits no tier reaches. Standardised difference is the difference in means over the pooled standard deviation; ‘cells’ reweights the unlinked group to the linked group’s distribution over permit type $\times$ 5-year filing bin $\times$ analysis neighbourhood (97.3% of linked permits have a counterpart cell), ‘units’ over type $\times$ bin $\times$ unit-count bin (99.7%). T3-only permits are in neither group.

Variable	Linked		Not linked		Std. difference		
	mean	median	mean	median	raw	cells	units
estimated cost (log)	12.55	12.69	11.39	11.88	0.43	0.19	0.13
estimated cost (\$)	6,135,886	325,000	771,479	145,000	0.28	0.10	0.07
revised cost (log)	12.99	13.09	11.85	12.04	0.47	0.22	0.15
existing units	4.0	1.0	11.4	1.0	-0.09	-0.08	-0.09
proposed units	21.6	2.0	11.2	1.0	0.12	0.07	-0.02
net units	3.6	0.0	-0.4	0.0	0.07	0.14	0.09
existing stories	2.5	2.0	5.3	2.0	-0.37	-0.11	-0.15
proposed stories	4.5	3.0	5.5	3.0	-0.10	0.07	0.01
filing year	2011	2010	2001	2000	0.98	0.02	0.02
existing use: one-family dwelling	26.2%		32.7%		-0.14	0.00	0.01
existing use: apartments	6.8%		11.3%		-0.15	-0.01	-0.01
proposed use: one-family dwelling	26.5%		32.9%		-0.14	-0.06	-0.01
proposed use: apartments	24.1%		16.0%		0.20	0.07	-0.01
proposed use: office	2.8%		11.8%		-0.35	-0.05	-0.02
proposed use: retail	1.7%		2.3%		-0.04	0.06	0.06
construction: wood frame	60.2%		68.4%		-0.17	-0.01	0.01
construction: type 1	11.9%		13.0%		-0.03	0.04	-0.02
zoning at filing: C-3 (downtown)	4.2%		3.1%		0.06	0.01	0.03
zoning at filing: NC / NCT (neighbourhood commercial)	11.3%		3.2%		0.32	0.04	0.04
zoning at filing: RH (house)	48.4%		33.6%		0.30	-0.06	-0.00
zoning at filing: RM (mixed)	10.6%		4.5%		0.23	0.04	0.05
outcome: issued	78.7%		81.5%		-0.07	0.13	0.13
outcome: days filed to issued	689.5	500.0	303.4	191.0	0.71	0.43	0.44

Variable	Linked		Not linked		Std. difference		
	mean	median	mean	median	raw	cells	units
outcome: construction started	40.3%		21.1%		0.43	0.12	0.09
outcome: completed	53.2%		56.8%		-0.07	0.05	0.03
outcome: expired or withdrawn	20.9%		31.7%		-0.25	-0.16	-0.13

Table 9: Outcomes within unit-count bins: linked against unlinked permits with the same number of proposed units, the unlinked group reweighted to the linked group’s type $\times$ filing bin $\times$ neighbourhood distribution. Bins with fewer than twenty linked permits are omitted.

Proposed units	Linked	Unlinked	Support	Issued		Days to issue		Expired or withdrawn	
				linked	unlinked	linked	unlinked	linked	unlinked
1	1,208	17,019	95.9%	82.6%	82.4%	712	438	29.2%	29.1%
2–4	1,127	13,047	92.2%	78.8%	68.4%	773	484	24.6%	35.4%
5–9	170	2,000	78.2%	57.1%	57.3%	786	446	21.8%	28.4%
10–19	152	1,370	66.4%	81.2%	82.4%	712	607	25.7%	23.8%
20–49	204	1,018	57.8%	77.1%	68.7%	631	461	14.4%	32.5%
50+	369	1,542	66.9%	79.8%	70.0%	534	401	9.7%	24.2%

Table 10: Three targeted comparisons. In each, the first group is the one named; the second is reweighted to it over the cells shown (‘support’ is the share of the first group with a counterpart cell). The DR comparison is a proxy: the Planning records carry no §311 notification record, so it compares the permits a DR request named with the other major permits in residential districts, where notice applies.

	First group	Second, raw	Second, reweighted	Std. diff. raw	reweighted
<i>DR track (proxy): major permits a DR request named vs other major permits in residential districts filed 2006–2020; cells type $\times$ filing year $\times$ neighbourhood; 487 vs 22,268, support 94.9%</i>					
estimated cost (log)	12.19	10.49	10.97	0.68	0.45
proposed units	4	8	6	-0.17	-0.18
issued	81.5%	80.1%	80.0%	0.04	0.05
days filed to issued	947	368	486	1.01	0.76
completed	50.3%	58.5%	58.9%	-0.16	-0.17
expired or withdrawn	23.4%	24.2%	21.0%	-0.02	0.06
<i>CU track: CU-linked vs same proposed use and zoning district, no Commission link; cells use $\times$ zoning $\times$ filing bin; 1,685 vs 53,366, support 90.7%</i>					
estimated cost (log)	12.90	11.42	11.40	0.54	0.50
proposed units	29	12	25	0.20	0.04
issued	72.8%	81.5%	70.5%	-0.20	0.05
days filed to issued	698	304	467	0.65	0.37
completed	51.5%	56.8%	48.7%	-0.11	0.06
expired or withdrawn	14.9%	31.6%	25.9%	-0.40	-0.27
<i>Ministerial vs Commission, new construction filed 2018 on: SB 35 / SB 423 vs Commission-linked; cells unit bin; 31 vs 434, support 100.0%</i>					
estimated cost (log)	16.86	15.11	16.81	1.02	0.03
proposed units	111	44	135	0.70	-0.20
issued	64.5%	38.5%	44.4%	0.54	0.41
days filed to issued	425	709	530	-0.70	-0.28
completed	48.4%	14.1%	23.1%	0.80	0.55
expired or withdrawn	3.2%	7.1%	7.2%	-0.18	-0.18

2 Types, statuses, and the permit clock

Table 3 counts permits by type and filing decade, one row per permit number (§9 gives the collapse rule). Over-the-counter alterations dominate every decade from the 1990s; new construction is a small share throughout. Table 4 is the status distribution: the exits — expired, withdrawn,

Table 11: Permits at the unit counts around the thresholds. Counts, not shares; the figure gives the full distribution. The 25-unit line is the brief’s figure for the July 2026 ordinance and has not been checked against the ordinance here; permits filed in 2026 are too few to show a response to it.

Group	Filed	7	8	9	10	11	12	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27
all development-relevant	<2016	157	247	168	132	84	253	96	30	105	46	42	27	56	32	34	25
all development-relevant	≥2016	192	200	123	94	51	63	29	32	30	29	27	20	27	22	10	16
Commission-linked	<2016	9	19	17	12	17	16	10	5	17	6	4	7	11	3	7	4
Commission-linked	≥2016	12	12	11	5	5	4	4	2	4	4	1	1	9	5	0	2

Table 12: The developer’s clock on the DR track. ‘DBI’ runs from the filing of the permit the DR is about (reached by T1 or T2) to the first DR hearing; ‘Planning record’ from the opening of the case’s record, the clock the data-acquisition memo used, to the same hearing. One row per DR case.

Clock	Cases	p25	Median	p75	p90	Negative
DBI permit filed → first hearing	2,356	183	294	498	791	3.0%
Planning record opened → first hearing	2,418	70	101	169	315	0.4%
DBI clock, cases with both	2,269	183	296	509	798	2.5%
Planning clock, cases with both	2,269	71	101	169	315	0.4%
difference (DBI – Planning)	2,269	68	150	338	623	8.9%

cancelled, disapproved, revoked, suspended — are marked, because they are the observable trace of a project that did not proceed.

Table 5 and Figure 1 give the clock: filed, issued, first construction document, completed, and the exits, by type and filing decade. Two features stand out. The time from filing to issuance for new construction has lengthened decade on decade; and every recent decade is right-censored — a permit filed in 2024 has not had time to be completed or to expire — so its completion and exit shares are floors, not rates. 0.18% of permits show an issuance before their filing; they are excluded from the medians rather than trimmed from the table.

3 A development-relevant universe

The question of whether Commission projects differ is not a question about kitchen remodels. Table 6 builds the comparison universe rule by rule and reports what each keeps: new construction of every construction type, demolitions, site permits, and additions or alterations that either change the dwelling-unit count or have an estimated cost in the top 5% of additions and alterations filed the same year. Over-the-counter alterations are excluded outright. The cost rule is a within-year percentile so that it means the same thing in 1985 and in 2025; a nominal threshold tilts the universe toward recent years, when nominal costs are higher. The sensitivity rows show the universe under the top 10% and top 2% and under a nominal \$1 million, with the Commission-linked share of each. The universe holds 57,883 permits.

4 Three linkage tiers, kept apart

Table 7 gives the tiers:

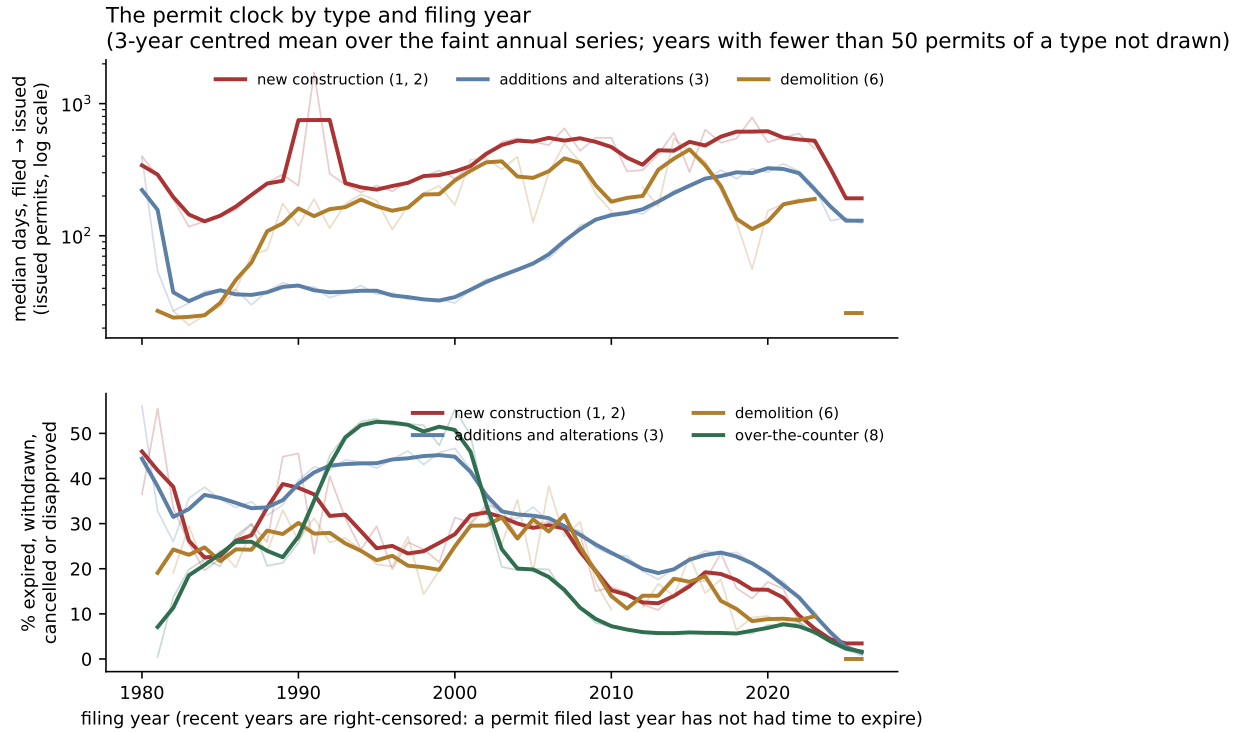


Figure 1: Top: median days from filing to issuance, by permit type and filing year, among issued permits; over-the-counter permits are issued the day they are filed and are drawn in the lower panel only. Bottom: the share of each year's permits that expired, were withdrawn, cancelled or disapproved. Faint lines are annual values; bold lines a 3-year centred mean; years with fewer than 50 permits of a type are not drawn. The last years are right-censored in both panels: the permits filed then that are already issued are the fast ones, and the rest have not had time to expire.

- **T1**, a permit number printed in the minutes, parsed and matched exactly as in the permit-linkage memo: 2,239 permits.
- **T2**, the Planning Department records’ `building_permits` field, read through the case, its parent project record and every record sharing its stem, as in the data-acquisition memo’s bridge: 5,518 permits. 1,627 are reached both ways.
- **T3**, the parcel + type + window rule — a major permit filed at the item’s parcel between three years before and one year after the hearing. Its precision of 0.72 and recall of 0.92 were measured on discretionary reviews, where the printed number is ground truth, and are unmeasured anywhere else.

“**Commission-linked**” means **T1 or T2**. T3 returns candidate sets whose error rate outside discretionary review is unknown, so T3-only permits — 1,773 of them in the universe — are reported as their own group and never pooled with either side of a comparison.

5 Are Commission projects different?

Table 8 compares the 4,517 Commission-linked permits in the universe with the development-relevant permits no tier reaches. Each row gives means and medians and the standardised difference three ways: raw; after reweighting the unlinked group to the linked group’s distribution over cells of permit type $\times$ 5-year filing bin $\times$ analysis neighbourhood (97.3% of linked permits have a counterpart cell); and after reweighting over type $\times$ filing bin $\times$ unit-count bin (99.7%). Table 9 repeats the outcome comparison within unit-count bins.

- **Era is the first difference, and cells remove it by construction.** Linked permits were filed on average in 2011 against 2001: both linkage routes reach recent permits better than old ones. Every raw difference in the table is partly this.
- **Scale.** Linked permits cost more: 0.43 standard deviations in log cost raw, 0.19 within cells, 0.13 within unit-count cells. Proposed units differ by 0.12 raw and 0.07 within cells. Some of the gap is where and when; the rest is that a project large enough to need a hearing is large.
- **Time.** Filing to issuance is where the linked group stands apart: 0.71 raw, 0.43 within cells and 0.44 within unit-count cells. Table 9 shows the gap in every unit-count bin. A project that appears in the minutes takes markedly longer from filing to permit than a similar project in the same neighbourhood and period that does not — which is the sign the real-options frame predicts for the cost of discretion, and which this table describes without identifying.
- **Abandonment.** Linked permits expire or are withdrawn less often (20.9% against 31.7%; -0.16 within cells). A project that has been through a hearing has sunk more by the time it holds a permit, and a project that would be abandoned may be abandoned before it ever reaches one.
- **Use and place.** Linked permits are more often apartments and less often offices or one-family dwellings, and more often in residential-house and neighbourhood-commercial districts at filing; within cells these differences mostly vanish, because the cells hold place and type fixed.

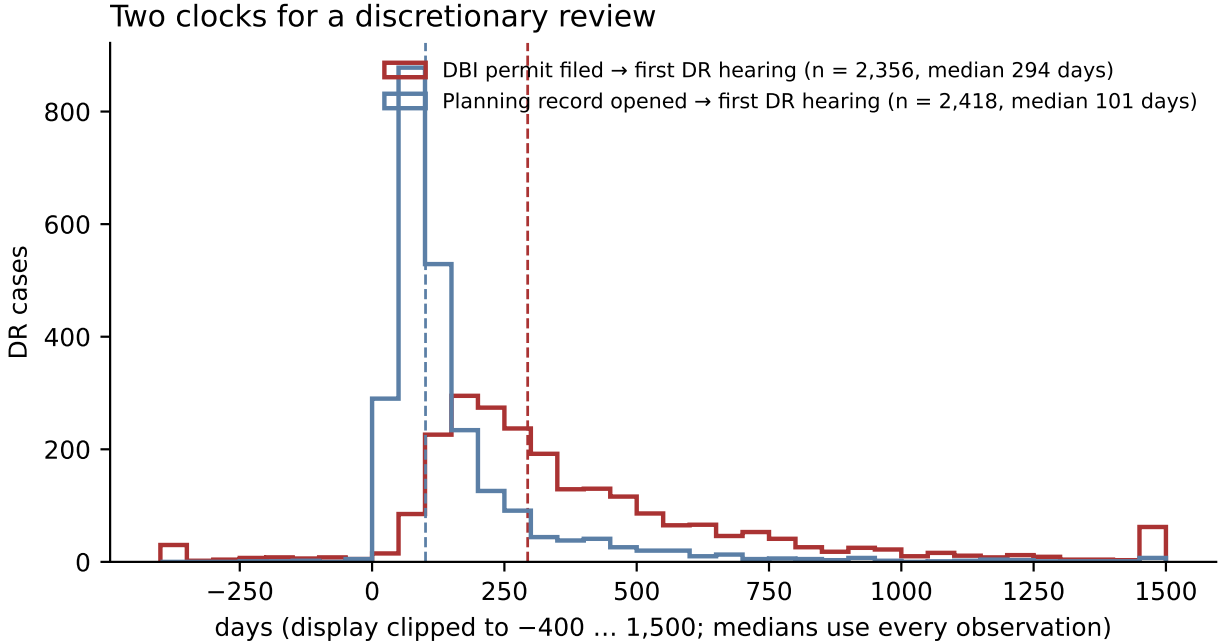


Figure 2: The two clocks on the discretionary-review track, one observation per DR case. The display is clipped; the medians use every observation.

6 Three targeted comparisons

Table 10 gives three narrower comparisons, each reweighted over the cells it names.

The DR track, as a proxy. The brief asked for noticed permits that drew a DR request against noticed permits that did not. **The Planning records do not identify §311 notification records:** no record type is a notice, and the text mentions notice mostly to say it was not required. What the records do identify is the DR request, whose description names its permit from 2015–2020; 646 of the 693 requests opened in those years do, and 487 of the named permits are major permits in DBI. They are compared with the other major permits filed 2006–2020 in residential districts, where notice applies. That is a comparison of permits that drew a DR request against permits that could have, not against permits known to have been noticed, and it is labelled a proxy wherever it appears.

The CU track. Permits linked to a conditional use, against development-relevant permits of the same proposed use in the same zoning district at filing, in the same filing period, with no Commission link.

Ministerial against Commission, 2018 on. New construction approved under SB 35 — flagged on 76 project records — or SB 423, which has no field and is found in 45 records only by its name in the text, reaches 31 permits in DBI, against 434 Commission-linked new-construction permits of the same period, reweighted over unit-count bins. The ministerial group is too small for its percentages to carry weight, and the table says so by giving the counts.

7 Bunching at the thresholds

Figure 3 and Table 11 give proposed units from 1 to 40 for every development-relevant permit and for the Commission-linked ones, before and after 2016 (Proposition C raised the inclusionary requirement that year). The lines mark the inclusionary threshold at 10 units, the Transportation Sustainability Fee’s residential tiers — which begin, as the fee register prints them, at 21, 100 units — and 25 units, the brief’s figure for the July 2026 ordinance, which this memo has not checked against the ordinance and which too few 2026 permits exist to test.

Read as counts, the distribution has visible heaping at round numbers in both periods, and the counts just below and just above each threshold are in Table 11 so the reader can judge. No bunching estimate is attempted here: the counts near any single threshold are in the tens, the Commission-linked counts in single digits, and a proposed unit count on a permit is not the same object as the count at entitlement.

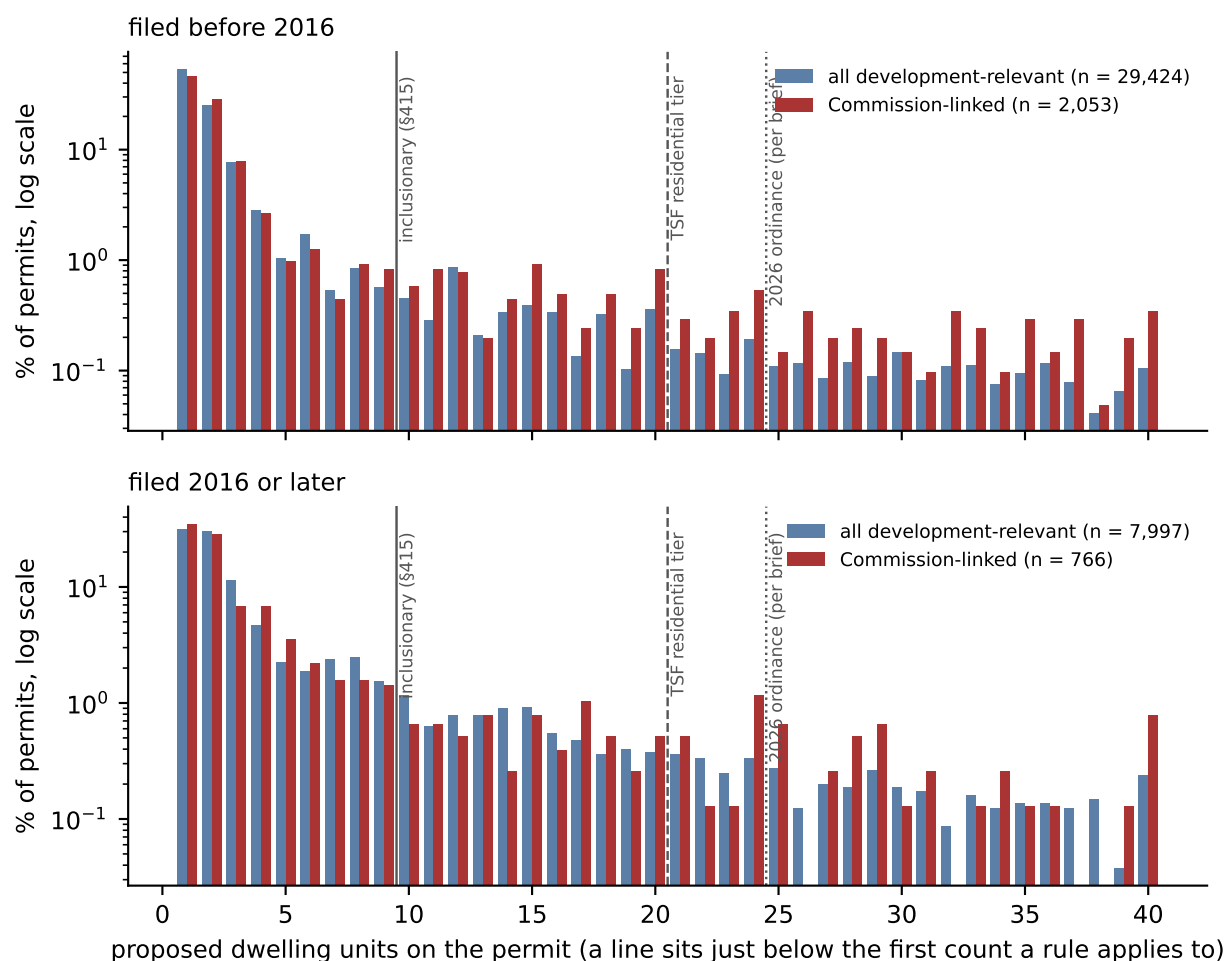


Figure 3: Proposed dwelling units on development-relevant permits, 1 to 40, as a share of each group, on a log scale; before and after 2016. The solid line sits just below the inclusionary threshold, the dashed lines below the TSF residential tiers, the dotted line below the brief’s 2026 threshold.

8 The developer’s clock on the DR track

The data-acquisition memo measured filing to first hearing from the opening of the Planning record. For a discretionary review that record is the DR request — filed by a neighbour against a pending permit — so the clock starts when the neighbour acts, not when the developer does. Table 12 and Figure 2 measure the developer’s clock instead: from the DBI filing of the permit the review is about, reached by T1 or T2, to the first DR hearing. On 2,356 of the 2,524 DR cases it is a median 294 days with a 90th percentile of 791; the Planning-record clock on 2,418 cases is a median 101 with a 90th percentile of 315. On the 2,269 cases with both, the developer’s clock is a median 150 days longer. 3.0% of the developer’s clocks are negative — the linked permit was filed after the first hearing — and they are kept rather than trimmed.

9 Caveats

- **Duplicate permit numbers.** 145,816 rows repeat a permit number already in the table, spread over 116,986 permits — one row per lot a permit touches. Every count here is on one row per permit, the earliest filed. DBI marks one row per permit itself (`primary_address_flag`); the two rules pick the same row for 94.6% of permits, and the choice barely matters for what is compared here: type, cost, units, dates and status differ between a permit’s rows for at most 0.01% of the permits that repeat.
- **T3 is unvalidated outside discretionary review**, and is never pooled.
- **Coverage rises with era.** Both Commission-linkage routes reach recent permits better than old ones, which is why every comparison is repeated within filing-period cells.
- **Linked does not mean the permit the hearing was about.** T2 in particular reads every record sharing a case stem, so a large project’s linked set can include permits for other phases or parcels of the same project. The comparison is of permits connected to a Commission case, not of the single permit each hearing decided.
- **The unlinked group is not a control group.** It is the set of development permits no route reaches, which includes Commission projects whose link is missing. If the missing links resemble the found ones, the differences are understated rather than overstated; either way they are descriptions, not effects.

10 Established, and not established

Established.

1. The table’s 57 columns, their fill by decade, and 17 columns whose rows do not deliver what the name suggests, including the absence of construction-start dates before the late 1990s.
2. A development-relevant universe of 57,883 permits under stated rules, reported beside three alternative cost rules.
3. Commission-linked development permits take longer from filing to issuance than similar unlinked permits in the same place, period and type, by 0.43 standard deviations, and the gap holds within every unit-count bin; they are larger, and less often abandoned.

4. The developer’s clock on the DR track runs a median 150 days longer than the Planning-record clock.

Not established.

1. Anything causal. The within-cell differences describe who reaches the Commission; they do not say what the hearing did.
2. Which of a linked set is the permit the hearing decided.
3. The §311 comparison as the brief framed it: notices are not in the records.
4. Whether the ministerial group, at 31 permits, is large enough to say anything.
5. Any response to the 2026 threshold.

11 Reproducing this

```
python analyze_permit_content.py fetch           # every column, resumable
python analyze_permit_content.py fetch --refresh # re-download
python analyze_permit_content.py report          # figures, tables, macros
```

`fetch` pages DataSF’s Building Permits on the system row identifier into one file per page under `$MFHR_DATA_ROOT/external/datasf/dbi_full_parts/` and stacks them into `dbi_permits_full.csv.gz`, with its retrieval time and column list beside it. `report` imports the printed-permit parser, the parcel rule and its window from `analyze_permits.py`, and the case normalisers, the planning records and the `building_permits` bridge from `acquire_external_data.py`; it joins the zoning district in force at filing from the parcel-year panel, reads the fee register for the TSF tiers, and writes the three figures, `tables/permits_content_tables.tex` and `tables/permits_content_macros.tex`. The linkage tiers are cached beside the DBI file and rebuilt whenever it is newer. The only numerals typed into the `.tex` are section references, identifiers, the twenty-two columns of the earlier cache, and the legal facts named as such (Proposition C, SB 35, SB 423, §311, the 1985 and 2025 of an example).